

2026–2027 Investment Competition Guide

Wharton Global High School Investment Competition

Welcome to the Competition

The Wharton Global High School Investment Competition challenges your team to develop, implement, and evaluate a long-term investment strategy designed to help a client achieve specific financial goals and meet future cash-flow needs.

Over the 10-week competition, your team will get to know the client, conduct research and analysis, develop an investment strategy, construct a portfolio, and evaluate your approach.

During the first six weeks, your team will develop and implement your investment strategy using the Wharton Investment Simulator (WInS). At the end of Week 6 (November 6), you will submit your Investment Policy Statement (IPS), trading will end, and your portfolio will be frozen.

Along the way, you will demonstrate how your investment decisions reflected your strategy through the Trading Notes Analysis, formally articulate and finalize your strategy in the IPS, and evaluate how you implemented that strategy in the Final Report.

Keep the Big Picture in Mind

Your investment strategy is the cornerstone of the competition.

This is not a competition to see which team can make the most money in a few weeks. Your challenge is to develop a thoughtful long-term investment strategy for your client and demonstrate that your investment decisions support that strategy.

From the beginning of the competition, your team should develop a strategy and use it to guide your research, portfolio construction, and investment decisions. The strategy may evolve as you learn more, but your decisions should reflect a clear and cohesive approach.

Let's Get Started

Start with Your Client

Before deciding what to invest in, you need to understand who you are investing for and what they are trying to accomplish.

Begin with the Client Case Study provided in SurveyMonkey Apply and carefully review the client's financial goals.

Your team will need to consider the client's goals, time horizons, required cash flows, funding commitments, liquidity needs, desired degree of funding certainty, risk tolerance, and communication with potential co-sponsors.

The case study is your starting point. It is up to your team to determine what additional research and analysis you need to develop and support your strategy. Review the complete Client Case Study (located under the **Pages** tab => **Client** on your team's SurveyMonkey Apply account) at the beginning of the competition, so you understand who your client is and what their investing goals are.

Develop Your Investment Strategy

Once you understand the investment challenge, your team needs to determine how you will approach it.

There is no single "correct" investment strategy for your client.

Your strategy should reflect your team's research and analysis into how to pursue growth, reliably meet future commitments, preserve flexibility, and manage risk.

As you develop your strategy, you will need to decide how to construct and diversify the portfolio, how its components will support different needs, how the portfolio's asset composition may change over time, and which principles will guide decisions as funding dates approach and payments are made.

The goal is not simply to identify investments you think will perform well. The goal is to develop a cohesive strategy in which your investment decisions work together to support the client's objectives across a range of possible market outcomes.

The IPS: Where Your Strategy Comes Together

Your Investment Policy Statement (IPS) is where your team formally articulates and finalizes its investment strategy.

Your research, analysis, Trading Notes, and experience implementing your strategy should all contribute to the IPS.

Review the complete **Investment Policy Statement Requirements** (located under the **Pages** tab => **Deliverables** on your team's SurveyMonkey Apply account) at the beginning of the competition, so you understand what you are working toward.

Once the IPS submission deadline passes, your investment strategy is final and may not be revised. Your portfolio and Final Report should reflect the strategy established in your IPS.

Putting Your Strategy into Action

The Role of WInS

WInS provides your team with the opportunity to put your investment strategy into action using real-world market conditions.

Use the simulator to research investments, construct your portfolio, make investment decisions, and experience how changing market conditions affect your holdings.

WInS is a tool for implementing your investment strategy. It is not the competition scorecard, and gains or losses generated during the WInS trading period should not be added to or subtracted from the client's long-term portfolio projections. Those projections should begin with the cash flows provided in the Client Case Study and use reasonable return assumptions consistent with your strategy.

You are **not** being evaluated based on:

- Your portfolio ranking
- How many trades you make
- Whether you outperform other teams
- Whether your portfolio makes money during the competition

A long-term investment strategy cannot be judged solely by what happens in the market over a few weeks. Instead, your portfolio provides evidence of the decisions your team made and how you put your strategy into practice.

Document Your Decision-Making

The decisions you make throughout the competition matter.

When your team executes a trade in WInS, the Trading Note should capture the reasoning behind the decision, including its alignment with your strategy, the supporting research or analysis, and its expected role in growth, liquidity, risk management, or future funding.

The Trading Notes Analysis is due at the end of Week 4 (October 23), two weeks before your IPS is due.

For the Trading Notes Analysis, your team will select three Trading Notes and reflect on how those decisions supported, tested, or refined your strategy. Although your strategy may continue to evolve before the IPS is submitted, your investment decisions should already reflect a clear strategic approach.

Do not treat Trading Notes as an afterthought. They provide a record of how your team put its strategy into practice. Review the complete Trading Notes Analysis Requirements (located under the **Pages** tab => **Deliverables** on your team's SurveyMonkey Apply account) at the beginning of the competition, so you understand what you are submitting.

Your Competition Road Map

The competition is designed as a progression. Each phase builds on the work that came before it.

1. UNDERSTAND

Get to know your client and the investment challenge.

Study the Client Case Study, financial goals, future funding commitments, and sources of uncertainty. Determine what additional research will help you understand the investment problem.

2. DEVELOP

Build your investment strategy.

Use research and analysis to establish the principles that will guide portfolio construction and balance growth, liquidity, funding reliability, and flexibility.

3. IMPLEMENT AND DOCUMENT

Put your strategy into action.

Use WInS to construct a portfolio that reflects your strategy, document the reasoning behind your trades, and demonstrate your decision-making through the Trading Notes Analysis.

4. ARTICULATE

Formally present and finalize your strategy in the IPS.

Clearly communicate the investment strategy your team developed, including how it addresses risk and uncertainty, as well as the framework that guides its investment decisions.

5. EVALUATE

Assess your strategy and its implementation in the Final Report.

Evaluate your implementation and explain why the strategy supports the client's operating commitment, facility contribution, financial flexibility, and communication with co-sponsors across varying outcomes.

How the Deliverables Connect

The competition deliverables are not separate assignments. Together, they show how your team developed, implemented, articulated, and evaluated its investment strategy.

DELIVERABLE	PURPOSE	WHAT IT SHOULD DEMONSTRATE
Trading Notes Analysis	Demonstrate your decision-making	Show how three investment decisions reflected your team's strategy and supported the client's goals, future funding needs, or constraints. Your strategy may continue to evolve before the IPS is submitted, but your decisions should already reflect a clear strategic approach.
Investment Policy Statement	Articulate your strategy	Present and finalize the strategy, including how it balances growth, liquidity, funding reliability, flexibility, risk, and uncertainty and guides portfolio decisions.
Final Report	Evaluate your strategy and implementation	Evaluate implementation of the IPS strategy and present the team's analysis and recommendations for the client's operating commitment, facility contribution, financial flexibility, and communication with co-sponsors across varying outcomes.

When the IPS Is Submitted

The IPS marks an important transition in the competition.

Once the IPS submission deadline passes:

- Your investment strategy is final.
- Trading ends and your WInS portfolio is frozen.
- You may not change your holdings.

Your team then moves from implementation to evaluation and reflection.

A long-term strategy may include planned adjustments as funding dates approach, but it should not be rewritten simply because markets move or hindsight reveals a different outcome.

You may identify decisions you would make differently, but you may not redesign your strategy after observing the results. Your focus now shifts to evaluating your implementation, reflecting on what you learned, and explaining why your strategy is appropriate for the client.

Key Dates

September 15: Competition Materials Released

- Access your Client Case Study, competition requirements, deliverable instructions, and supporting resources through SurveyMonkey Apply.
- The WInS practice period also begins. Use this time to become familiar with the simulator.

September 28: Competition Begins

- Official trading begins.

October 9: Official Team Roster Due

October 23: Trading Notes Analysis Due

- Demonstrate how three investment decisions reflected your strategy and supported the client's goals, funding needs, or approach to risk.

November 6: Investment Policy Statement Due

- Finalize your strategy and its approach to growth, liquidity, funding reliability, flexibility, risk, and uncertainty.
- Trading ends and your WInS portfolio is frozen.

December 4: Final Report and School Documentation Due

- Evaluate how your team implemented its strategy and present your analysis and recommendations for the client's operating commitment, facility contribution, financial flexibility, and communication with co-sponsors across a range of possible outcomes.

What Are We Looking For?

The competition recognizes thoughtful strategy, research and analysis, client understanding, disciplined decisions, management of risk and uncertainty, communication, and creativity.

Judges want to understand not only what your team decided to do, but also the reasoning, assumptions, and tradeoffs behind those decisions.

Your work should demonstrate an understanding of the client, informed investment decisions, and clear communication of how your approach supports the client's goals while addressing risk and uncertainty.

Review the **Evaluation Criteria** before you begin (located under the **Pages** tab => **Deliverables** on your team's SurveyMonkey Apply account) and revisit them throughout the competition.